

Active Listening

10-Week Leadership Development Program

Daily Habit	Weekly Deliverable	Reading
In every conversation, after the other person finishes, paraphrase: 'What I hear you saying is...' Do not give advice or your opinion until you've done this.	Have one 10-minute conversation where you only ask questions and paraphrase — never stating your own view.	Connect: Building Exceptional Relationships with Family, Friends, and Colleagues — Chapter on Deep Listening (David Bradford & Carole Robin) + The 7 Habits, Habit 5: Seek First to Understand, Then to Be Understood (Covey)

Core Concept

Most people do not listen to understand — they listen to reply. While someone is speaking, we are already formulating our response, evaluating what they're saying, or waiting for a pause to jump in. Covey calls this 'autobiographical listening' — we filter everything through our own experience.

Deep listening is rare, and therefore powerfully distinctive. When someone feels genuinely heard — not just heard, but understood — trust forms rapidly. Research on therapeutic relationships shows that feeling heard is the single most powerful predictor of relationship quality.

For leaders, listening is not passive. It is an active, skilled behavior that requires discipline: suspending judgment, resisting the urge to fix, asking clarifying questions, and reflecting back what you've heard before adding your own perspective.

""Most people do not listen with the intent to understand; they listen with the intent to reply.""

— Stephen R. Covey

Framework: The Listening Ladder

Level 1 — Cosmetic listening: You appear to listen but are thinking about something else.

Level 2 — Conversational listening: You hear the words and respond to the surface meaning.

Level 3 — Active listening: You listen for meaning, emotion, and what's left unsaid. You paraphrase and clarify.

Level 4 — Deep listening: You listen for the person's worldview, values, and underlying needs. You make them feel fully seen.

Most leaders operate at Level 2. Exceptional leaders operate at Level 3 and 4.

Daily Practice

- Before any important conversation: Set an intention — 'I will seek to understand before I speak.'
- During conversations: Notice when you feel the urge to jump in, give advice, or share your own story. Let the urge pass. Ask one more question instead.
- Paraphrase practice: After each person speaks, say 'What I'm hearing is...' or 'It sounds like...' before you respond.
- Ask the 'What else?' question: After someone shares something, ask 'What else is on your mind about that?' It almost always unlocks deeper information.

Leadership Scenarios

Scenario 1

A team member comes to you overwhelmed: 'I have too much on my plate and I don't know how to prioritize.'

Reflection: What do you say first? Practice paraphrasing their concern before offering any solution.

Scenario 2

Your peer gives you feedback that feels unfair.

Reflection: Can you repeat back exactly what they said — including the emotional subtext — before you respond?

Weekly Reflection Prompts

Set aside 20 minutes at the end of this week to write your responses. These are for you — be honest.

Reflection 1: Who in your life do you find hardest to truly listen to? What gets in the way?

Reflection:

Reflection 2: Describe a time when you felt genuinely heard. What did the other person do? How did it affect the conversation?

Reflection:

Reflection 3: What is your most common listening failure — jumping to advice, relating it to your own experience, interrupting, or something else?

Reflection:

Weekly Habit Tracker

Day	Done?	Notes / Observations
Monday	■	
Tuesday	■	
Wednesday	■	
Thursday	■	
Friday	■	
Saturday	■	
Sunday	■	

End-of-Week Summary

Reflection: What was my biggest leadership learning this week?

Reflection: What will I carry forward into next week?

Reflection: One relationship I invested in this week: